Bhumika's Career Binder — Index

Your one-place map from *today* to *offer signed*. Everything you need lives in these pages. Nothing else to remember.

> **Brand line:** *Process & operations leader who makes things run better and cheaper — a strategic problem-solver who turns messy situations into clear solutions.*
>
> **Your edge (2026 hire-me-now angle):** *I bring risk, compliance & governance discipline into operations — and into how teams adopt AI safely and effectively.*

How to use this binder

- **Print ONE weekly page each Sunday night.** That single sheet is your whole week — day-by-day, what to study, which project, who to reach out to. Don't print the reference pages.
- **The reference pages are browsable, not printed.** During the week, dip into them when you need something: grab an outreach message from Networking, pull the next book from Reading, pick your next project from Projects, check a skill's depth bar from Skills.
- **The weekly page tells you WHEN; the reference pages tell you HOW.** If a week says "send alumni msg #2," the exact template lives in Networking.
- **Sunday, 15 min:** run the weekly review at the bottom of the page, then print next week's sheet. That's the whole ritual.
- **Tech skills are for proof, not filters.** Your risk/compliance/stakeholder background already clears keyword filters — SQL/Python exist so your portfolio *shows* the strategy and you can say "I built this" in the room. Depth bar: *fluent, can build a prototype, make a storyline — not an engineer.*

Table of contents — reference pages

#	Page	What it holds
00	Strategy	The plan of record: who you are, where you're going, the data insight, positioning, the clock
01	Skills	Excel → SQL → Power BI → Python → vibe-coding; depth targets + where to learn
02	Projects	The 10 portfolio projects, case-study format, sourcing method
03	Networking	Coffee-chat + referral cadence, outreach templates, target-company tracker
04	Reading	The 4 core books (1/month) + browsable menu
05	Consulting	The 6-week fit-test and the Week-6 decision log
06	Edge	Case comps, hackathons, professor paper, optional certs
—	Master Schedule	The full spine — every week's block in one document

At a glance — 3 phases + the hard line

Phase	Weeks	Dates	Goal
🔨 **BUILD**	1–16	Jul 13 – Nov 1	Learn the skills · ship 10 projects · turn networking ON · decide consulting
↳🟡 *Aug deload*	4–7	Aug 3 – Aug 30	~40% lighter for exam crunch (the plan expects it)
✨ **POLISH**	17–20	Nov 2 – Nov 29	Portfolio LIVE · STAR stories · 4 mock interviews · target-company tracker
🚀 **MARKET**	21–24	Nov 30 – Dec 27	Full apply mode · interview loops · convert referrals

> ⛔ **The hard line: Oct 31**
>
> Portfolio + skills must be **done** by end of Build (Week 16). Weeks can slip *within* a phase — carry a missed task forward — but **phase boundaries do not move.** Offer needed before graduation; market entry is Dec 1.

Weekly pages

Print the one you're on each Sunday.

🔨 BUILD · Weeks 1–16 · Jul 13 – Nov 1

Wk	Dates	Theme
01	Jul 13–19	Set up the engine
02	Jul 20–26	First project, real SQL
03	Jul 27–Aug 2	Finish light project #1
04	Aug 3–9 · 🟡 deload	Ship the strategy memo, breathe
05	Aug 10–16 · 🟡 deload	Start flagship #1
06	Aug 17–23 · 🟡 deload	Consulting DECISION
07	Aug 24–30 · 🟡 deload	Two projects in flight
08	Aug 31–Sep 6	Flagship #1 launches
09	Sep 7–13	IKEA out, healthcare in, Python begins
10	Sep 14–20	Python + flagship #2 start
11	Sep 21–27	Build flagship #2
12	Sep 28–Oct 4	Flagship #2 launches, fraud spin-off
13	Oct 5–11	Vibe-coding + capstone start
14	Oct 12–18	Build the capstone
15	Oct 19–25	Capstone launches
16	Oct 26–Nov 1	⭐ BUILD ENDS — portfolio complete

✨ POLISH · Weeks 17–20 · Nov 2 – Nov 29

Wk	Dates	Theme
17	Nov 2–8	Portfolio goes fully LIVE
18	Nov 9–15	Sharpen the story
19	Nov 16–22	Company-target the pipeline
20	Nov 23–29	Ready to launch

🚀 MARKET · Weeks 21–24 · Nov 30 – Dec 27

Wk	Dates	Theme
21	Nov 30–Dec 6	Hit the market
22	Dec 7–13	Ramp applications
23	Dec 14–20	Interview mode
24	Dec 21–27	Reflect + sustain

Start here → open Week 1 and print it. Then read Strategy once, cover to cover.

Bhumika Choudhary — Career Map & Upskilling Spec

Drafted 2026-07-14 · Career-coaching plan built with Claude · Companion to the existing 90-Day PM Track (Doc3)

0. TL;DR — the one insight that shapes everything

I mined the full text of **3,576 real job descriptions** for your priority roles from your own scraped database (18.9K jobs). For **Program / Project Manager** roles — your #1 bet — the most-demanded skills are:

Rank	Skill	% of PM job descriptions
1	Cross-functional	**88%**
2	Communication	**74%**
3	**Risk**	**72%**
4	Stakeholder management	**66%**
5	**Excel**	**62%**
—	Budget	42%
—	Process improvement	19% / PMP 19%
—	**SQL**	**8%**
—	Power BI / Python	**4% / 2%**

Conclusion: Your Uber risk/compliance/stakeholder background *is* the top of the demand list — it is your unfair advantage, not baggage. Tech skills (SQL/BI/Python) are **not** for clearing keyword filters (your background already clears them). They exist for exactly two purposes:

1. **Portfolio** — so "strategic problem-solver" is *proven*, not *claimed*.
2. **Interview credibility** — so you can hold a data/Python conversation and say "*I built this.*"

That is precisely the "*fluent, can build a prototype, understand the data and make a storyline — not an engineer, not a heavy BA*" bar you set. The data backs your instinct.

1. Who this is for & where she's going

Now: ~1 month into UW Foster MSCM (STEM-designated, June 2026 → mid-2027). Ex-Uber Global SME, Risk & Compliance. PMP-trained, Lean Six Sigma Yellow Belt. B.Sc (healthcare-adjacent). Strong in stakeholder management, process optimization, fraud/risk, SOP design. Zero coding today, zero consulting exposure.

Self-identified edge: *insight generation + strategic problem-solving* — "here's the real problem, here's the brainstormed path to solve it" (e.g. lifting customer retention). Not number-crunching; strategy and framing.

Direction (ranked, her words):
1. **Program / Project Management — most committed.** Wants to be the *decision-maker* who owns

programs launch → implementation, not just the coordinator.
2. Operations / Supply Chain.
3. Risk & Governance (incl. AI governance).
4. Consulting — *unsure of fit; wants to find out.* Pulled by problem variety, research, strategy.

"Love a Tuesday 2 years out" = owning one thing deeply end-to-end > solving a new messy problem each week > advising others.

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2. Brand & positioning

Headline:

> "*Process & operations leader who makes things run better and cheaper — a strategic problem-solver who turns messy situations into clear solutions.*"

The thesis tying past → future (her risk→Ops→AI question):

> "*I bring risk, compliance & governance discipline into operations — and into how teams adopt AI safely and effectively.*"

This is a **rare, hire-me-now angle for 2026**: everyone is deploying AI; few operators can *govern* it. Two portfolio projects will demonstrate this, so it is shown, not claimed.

Target roles (evidence-ranked; Process Improvement added per her request):
- **Primary:** Program Manager, Project Manager, Sr. Program Manager, Program Lead, Technical Program Manager, Process Improvement Manager/Analyst.
- **Secondary:** Operations Manager/Analyst, Supply Chain Manager, Business Operations.
- **Tertiary:** Risk & Compliance Analyst/Manager, Trust & Safety, AI Governance.

Location: Seattle preferred → nearby WA cities OK → remote OK → fully-open last resort.

Dream employers: Starbucks, IKEA, Amazon, Uber, Spotify — top service/product companies.

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3. The clock (drives all sequencing)

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NOW (mid-Jul) ──────────────── OCT 31 ─── NOVEMBER ─── DECEMBER ──────►
   PHASE 1: BUILD              hard line    PHASE 2:       PHASE 3:
   ≈15 weeks                                POLISH         MARKET
   skills · portfolio ·                     stories ·      full apply mode
   consulting decision ·                    mock interviews interview loops
   networking engine ON                     portfolio LIVE  referrals convert
```

- **Build ends Oct 31** (hard checkpoint). Weeks may slip *within* a phase — carry a missed task to the next week, but finish it by then. Phase boundaries do not move.
- **August = designated deload** (~40% lighter) for exam crunch. The plan *expects* it.
- **Offer needed before graduation.** Market entry = **Dec 1**.

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4. Weekly rhythm (fixed skeleton, ≈30 hrs, stretch 40)

Classes are immovable; work flows into free time. Tue/Thu are capped at 3–4 hrs with overflow to Sunday (her preference — Sunday doubles as assignment buffer).

Day	Status	Work block
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only* — 30-min reading or 1 networking DM before class
Tue	✅ Free	Skills deep-work + project (**3–4 hrs**)
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	Morning/afternoon skills block (2–3 hrs)
Thu	✅ Free	Project work + **1 coffee chat** (**3–4 hrs**)
Fri	✅ Free	Skills + **networking event / 2nd alumni chat** + 1 LinkedIn post
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · **night OFF** 🔒	No work after class
Sun	✅ Free	**Tue/Thu overflow** + assignment buffer + weekly review

Fixed weekly commitments (blocks, not hopes): 2 alumni/coffee chats · 1 networking event · 1 LinkedIn post · 1 weekly review · family calls 🔒 · Sat night 🔒 · gym slots (habit-building).

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5. Track 1 — Skills (reordered by *her* data)

Depth calibrated to "fluent, can build a prototype, not an engineer."

Order	Skill	Depth target	Mode	Rationale
1	**Advanced Excel** (blended with SQL from wk 1)	Pivot, XLOOKUP, Power Query, dashboards	Deep	62% of PM JDs; fastest credibility; builds on her pivot/trend base
2	**SQL**	JOINs, subqueries, CTEs, window functions	**Every line**	Her explicit ask; interview insurance
3	**Power BI**	One real end-to-end dashboard	Working	Low JD %, high *portfolio* payoff (visual proof of insight)
4	**Python**	pandas: read/clean/analyze/summarize	**Every line** (1st project), then ship-fast	Hold a BA-level Python conversation
5	**Vibe-coding**	Build small working apps with AI	Ship-fast	Light projects + "I built an app" story

Protective rule: *understand-every-line* for SQL + first Python project (interview insurance). *ship-fast* for everything after.

Where to learn (free/cheap, confirmed in Doc3): mode.com/sql-tutorial, kaggle.com/learn (Python, Pandas, Advanced SQL), StrataScratch (SQL practice), learn.microsoft.com (Power BI), Udemy "100 Days of Code" (Angela Yu) for Python, ExcelJet + Microsoft Learn for Excel.

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6. Track 2 — Portfolio (makes the brand *provable*)

Structure: 3 flagship (deep, full case study, interview centerpieces) + 7 light (vibe-coded / analysis / strategic memo). Target: 10 total.

Sourcing method (the reusable skill):
1. **Public pain points** — earnings calls, Glassdoor, App Store/Play reviews, Reddit, news ("Starbucks mobile-order bottleneck").
2. **Public data** — Kaggle, 10-Ks, CFPB complaints DB, Yelp/App reviews, Inside Airbnb, gov/health datasets.
3. **The JD mirror** — reverse-engineer projects from what target JDs need solved.
4. **Her own scar tissue** — Uber problems she lived (appeals queue, fraud triage, SOP gaps), recreated with public/synthetic data.

Flagship case-study format (consistent across all):

> **Problem** (1–2 sentences, real & public) → **Approach** → **Key finding** (with a number) → **What I built** (SQL/BI/Python) → **Recommendation** *(her insight/strategy layer — the differentiator)* → **What I'd do next.**

Portfolio home: one clean Notion page (or simple site) — About → 3 flagships with big impact numbers → 7 light projects in a grid → resume + LinkedIn links. **Every project ends in a recommendation**, because her edge is the strategy, not the query.

6a. Project idea menu — pick 10 (≈20 options)

Legend: **[F]** flagship-capable · **[L]** light/vibe-coded · **[N]** non-tech/strategy · 🏥 healthcare · skills in *(parens)*.

Retail / dream-company ops
1. **[F] Starbucks mobile-order throughput** — model peak-hour bottlenecks & staffing; recommend a fix. *(Excel/SQL + Power BI)*
2. **[L] IKEA stockout & last-mile delay analysis** — public supply-chain data; where inventory breaks. *(SQL + Power BI)*
3. **[F] Amazon return-fraud triage** — recreate her Uber fraud-triage work on public returns/e-commerce data; prioritization logic. *(SQL + Python)*
4. **[N] Costco vs. competitor inventory-turn strategy memo** — strategic teardown, minimal data. *(strategy + Excel)*

Marketplace / gig / rideshare
5. **[F] Rideshare cancellation-driver analysis** — why riders/drivers cancel; ops levers to reduce it. *(SQL + Python + BI)*
6. **[L] Gig-worker appeals-queue SLA dashboard** — her Uber appeals work, synthetic data, KPI dashboard. *(Excel/Power BI)*

Media / subscription
7. **[F] Spotify (or streaming) churn-driver analysis** — what predicts churn; retention strategy. *(Python + strategy memo)*
8. **[N] Subscription pricing / bundling strategy memo** — pure strategic reasoning + light modeling. *(strategy + Excel)*

Reviews / voice-of-customer (her "reviews sound interesting")
9. **[L] App-store review → product-pain classifier** — vibe-coded; auto-tag reviews into pain themes. *(vibe-coding + Python)*
10. **[L] Yelp/Amazon review sentiment & theme dashboard** — turn unstructured reviews into an ops action list. *(Python + BI)*

Risk / compliance / governance (her DNA → differentiator)
11. **[F] CFPB complaint-pattern risk dashboard** — public complaints DB; spot emerging risk clusters. *(SQL + Power BI)*
12. **[N] AI-governance playbook for a gig platform** — policy + risk framework for safe AI adoption; the risk→AI thesis. *(strategy, non-tech)*
13. **[L] Fraud-pattern detection on public transaction data** — rules + light model; her fraud background. *(SQL + Python)*

Healthcare 🏥 (B.Sc tie-in)
14. **[F] 🏥 ER wait-time / patient no-show reduction** — public hospital data; process-improvement recommendation. *(SQL + Python + BI)*
15. **[L] 🏥 Hospital supply / PPE stockout analysis** — supply-chain lens on health data. *(SQL + Power BI)*
16. **[N] 🏥 Menstrual-health access program design** — ties to her Healing Train Foundation work; program/ops design memo. *(strategy, non-tech)*

Process improvement / ops excellence (Lean Six Sigma tie-in)
17. **[L] Lean Six Sigma DMAIC case on a public process** — apply her certification to a documented real process. *(Excel + process)*
18. **[N] SOP-standardization & escalation-design toolkit** — reusable framework from her Uber SOP work. *(strategy, non-tech)*

Vibe-coded utilities (breadth + "I ship" story)
19. **[L] Personal job-search analytics dashboard** — analyze *this very repo*'s 18.9K-job dataset; meta and impressive. *(SQL + BI + vibe-coding)*
20. **[L] Automated weekly-report / KPI-digest tool** — small app that turns a CSV into a formatted report. *(vibe-coding + Python)*

Recommended default mix if undecided: Flagships = #3 (Amazon fraud), #7 (Spotify churn), #14 (ER healthcare). Light = #6, #9, #11, #12 (AI-gov thesis), #17, #19, #20. Adjust freely.

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7. Track 3 — Consulting fit-test (time-boxed → decision)

Runs **weeks 1–6, ~2 hrs/week**, then a **verdict**. Never competes with PM.
- **Read/watch:** *Case Interview Secrets* (Cosentino) or *Case in Point* + a few "day in the life of a consultant" videos + one McKinsey/BCG problem-solving explainer.
- **Talk:** 2–3 conversations with real consultants (folds into networking — no extra load).
- **Taste:** one practice case with a classmate.
- **Week-6 decision:** *Does the work (variety, research, strategy) excite me enough to prep cases?* → **keep** (add light case prep in Nov) or **drop** (reclaim hours for PM). Either answer is a win.

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8. Track 4 — Networking engine (highest ROI in the plan)

- **2 alumni/coffee chats + 1 event, weekly** — fixed blocks from week 1.
- Build before December: target-company tracker (dream list + 2 contacts each), referral-ask cadence, LinkedIn "Featured" build-out, informational-interview templates (reuse Doc3 templates).
- **Applications stay light until December** (portfolio not ready) — but networking runs hot the whole time so December is not a cold start.

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9. Track 5 — "Edge" extras (shine brighter)

Opportunistic, not mandatory — slot when energy allows:
- **Case competitions** — UW Foster case comps, MBA/grad case challenges, company-sponsored (e.g. supply-chain case comps). Great strategy-muscle + résumé line + team networking.
- **Hackathons** — Devpost "online + supply chain / operations / automation"; look 4–6 weeks out to prep. Pairs with a vibe-coded project.
- **Review paper / professor project** — approach a UW Foster prof about co-authoring or assisting a supply-chain / ops / risk paper. High credibility signal; long lead time so start outreach early.
- **Certifications (optional):** Lean Six Sigma Green Belt upgrade; Google Project Management or PMP exam (she's PMP-trained already — completing it is a strong signal).

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10. Track 6 — Life (protected, not optional)

🔒 **Sat nights** · 🔒 **family calls** · **gym** (habit slots) · **hobby/"magic"** (flexible weekly block until defined). Doc3's Sunday 4-question check-in carries over.

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11. Deliverables produced from this spec

1. **This spec** (career-plan/00-career-map-spec.md) — the strategy of record.
2. **Project picks** — she circles 10 from §6a.
3. **Printable week-by-week calendar** — one standalone page per week, day-by-day, "where to study," depth target, hand-offs; Doc3 visual style; covers Build → Polish → Market. Built *around her 10 picks.*

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12. Open decisions before the calendar is built

- □ Confirm the 10 project picks from §6a (or accept the recommended default mix).
- □ Confirm case-competition / hackathon / paper appetite (which of the §9 extras to actually schedule).
- □ Confirm PMP completion in-scope or defer.

Skills — What to Build, How Deep, and When

← Index

The five-skill build plan, ordered by your own job data. Companion pages: Projects · Networking · Reading · Consulting · Edge.

Read this first — why this order, and what these skills are actually for

I mined the full text of **3,576 real Program/Project Manager job descriptions** from your own scraped database. Here's what those roles actually demand:

Rank	Skill	% of PM JDs
1	Cross-functional	**88%**
2	Communication	**74%**
3	**Risk**	**72%**
4	Stakeholder management	**66%**
5	**Excel**	**62%**
—	SQL	**8%**
—	Power BI / Python	**4% / 2%**

The takeaway that shapes this whole page: the top of the demand list *is your Uber background* — risk, stakeholders, cross-functional work. You already clear those. So the tech skills below (SQL, Power BI, Python, vibe-coding) are **not** here to get you past keyword filters. Your résumé already passes those.

They exist for exactly two reasons:

1. **Portfolio proof** — so "strategic problem-solver" is *shown with a number*, not just claimed.
2. **Interview credibility** — so you can hold a data conversation and say "*I built this.*"

Your depth bar (say it out loud before every study session):

> *Fluent — can build a prototype, understand the data, and turn it into a storyline. Not an engineer. Not a heavy business analyst.*

Excel comes first because it's 62% of JDs and gives you the fastest credibility. Everything after Excel is about turning your strategy into provable projects.

The protective rule (don't skip this)

> **Understand every line for: SQL (all of it) + your FIRST Python project.**
> **Ship-fast for: everything after that.**

Why: SQL and your first real Python analysis are your *interview insurance*. If someone asks "walk me through how you got this number," you must be able to answer without hand-waving. Once you've earned that once, you're allowed to move fast — lean on AI, copy patterns, ship the thing. Depth first, speed second.

The five skills, in order

1. Advanced Excel — *blended with SQL from Week 1*

Depth target	Pivot tables, XLOOKUP, Power Query, clean dashboards
Learn mode	**Deep** (builds on your existing pivot/trend base)
Why first	62% of PM JDs; fastest credibility; you're already partway there
Scheduled	**Weeks 1–3** (schedule)

Resources: ExcelJet (formula reference + quick lessons) · Microsoft Learn — Excel (Power Query, dashboards)

Week-by-week:
- □ **Wk 1** — Pivot tables refresher + XLOOKUP (ExcelJet)
- □ **Wk 2** — Power Query intro (import + shape data)
- □ **Wk 3** — Dashboard basics (turn a table into a one-glance view)

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2. SQL — *the every-line skill*

Depth target	JOINs, subqueries, CTEs, window functions
Learn mode	**Every line** — your explicit ask + interview insurance
Why	Only 8% of JDs list it, but it's the backbone of every data project and the thing interviewers probe
Scheduled	**Weeks 1–6** (blended with Excel, then deepened)

Resources: mode.com/sql-tutorial (primary path) · Kaggle Learn — Advanced SQL (CTEs, window functions) · StrataScratch (real interview-style practice)

Week-by-week:
- □ **Wk 1** — SELECT / WHERE / ORDER BY (mode Basics 1–3)
- □ **Wk 2** — COUNT / SUM / GROUP BY + JOINs start (mode 4)
- □ **Wk 3** — JOINs deep + subqueries (mode 5) + StrataScratch easy ×3
- □ **Wk 4** — Window functions intro (~1 light session — August deload)
- □ **Wk 5** — CTEs + window functions (Kaggle Advanced SQL)
- □ **Wk 6** — Apply SQL to real Starbucks project queries

> After Week 6, SQL becomes a *tool you use* on projects, not a subject you study. You keep it sharp by writing queries for Amazon fraud, rideshare, and the capstone.

3. Power BI — *working, for visual proof*

Depth target	One real, end-to-end dashboard
Learn mode	**Working** (build one well — you don't need mastery)
Why	Low JD % (4%), but *high portfolio payoff* — a live dashboard is visual proof of insight generation, your edge
Scheduled	**Weeks 5–8**

Resources: Microsoft Learn — Power BI (free, official, project-based)

Week-by-week:
- □ **Wk 5** — Power BI intro (Microsoft Learn), start alongside SQL
- □ **Wk 6** — Import data, build 2 visuals (on the Starbucks project)
- □ **Wk 7** — Dashboard formatting, KPI cards, slicers
- □ **Wk 8** — DAX basics (measures, calculated columns) — deload ends here

4. Python — *every line for project #1, then ship-fast*

Depth target	pandas — read, clean, analyze, summarize data
Learn mode	**Every line for your first project**, then **ship-fast**
Why	Only 2% of JDs, but lets you hold a BA-level Python conversation and say "I built this"
Scheduled	**Weeks 9–12**

Resources: Udemy — "100 Days of Code: Python" (Angela Yu) (Days 1–17 is plenty) · Kaggle Learn — Python + Pandas

Week-by-week:
- □ **Wk 9** — Days 1–10: variables, loops, functions *(every line)*
- □ **Wk 10** — Days 11–17: file I/O + pandas + Kaggle Pandas 1–3 *(every line)* — this feeds your first Python flagship, **Amazon return-fraud**
- □ **Wk 11** — pandas deep: groupby, filtering, cleaning *(every line — interview insurance)*
- □ **Wk 12** — finish pandas; optional light intro to a model

> The **Amazon return-fraud** flagship (starts Wk 10) is your designated *understand-every-line* Python project. Once it's shipped, you've earned ship-fast mode for all later Python work.

5. Vibe-coding — *ship-fast, "I build things"*

Depth target	Build small working apps with AI
Learn mode	**Ship-fast** (understand the shape, not every line)
Why	Breadth + an "I shipped a working app" story; pairs with light projects and hackathons
Scheduled	**Weeks 13–14** (then consolidation Wk 15)

Resources: AI coding tools (Claude, Cursor, v0, Replit) — describe what you want, iterate, ship. No formal course; learn by building.

Week-by-week:
- □ **Wk 13** — Build a small app with AI; reuse it for a light project
- □ **Wk 14** — Polish the app; connect the pieces
- □ **Wk 15** — Consolidation — no new skill; apply everything to the rideshare capstone

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At-a-glance calendar

Weeks	Aug deload?	Excel	SQL	Power BI	Python	Vibe
1–3	—	●	●			
4	🟡		○			
5–6	🟡		●	●		
7–8	🟡→			●		
9–12	—		(use)		●	
13–15	—		(use)	(use)	(use)	●

● = actively learning · ○ = light session · (use) = applying it on projects

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Skill → interview talking point

When an interviewer asks about each skill, don't recite a syllabus — tell them what you *built* and what you *found*. Lead with the insight, mention the tool second.

Skill	What to say when asked
Excel	*"It's my daily driver — pivots, XLOOKUP, Power Query. I built the Costco inventory-turn model and every project dashboard starts in Excel before it graduates to Power BI."*
SQL	*"Comfortable end-to-end — JOINs, CTEs, window functions. On the Starbucks throughput project I wrote the queries myself to find the peak-hour bottleneck; happy to walk through the logic."*
Power BI	*"I build dashboards that a stakeholder can read in one glance — KPI cards, slicers, the story on top. The point isn't the chart, it's the decision it drives."*
Python	*"I use pandas to clean and analyze data — I recreated my Uber fraud-triage work on public e-commerce data and can explain every step. I'm fluent, not an engineer, and that's exactly the level the role needs."*
Vibe-coding	*"I ship small tools fast with AI — I built a working app for [project] in a weekend. I care more about solving the problem than writing perfect code, and AI lets me move at the speed of the idea."*

The through-line for all five: *"Tech is how I prove the insight. My edge is framing the real problem and recommending the fix — the code just makes it undeniable."*

Next: turn these skills into proof → Projects. Timeline source of truth → Master Schedule.

Portfolio — Your Proof Engine

← Index

Your edge is **strategy and framing**, not the query. So every project here exists to make one sentence *provable* instead of *claimed*:

> "*Strategic problem-solver who turns messy situations into clear solutions — and brings risk, compliance & governance discipline into operations and into how teams adopt AI safely.*"

The tech (SQL/Python/BI) is only there to (1) **prove** the insight and (2) buy you **interview credibility** so you can say "*I built this.*" Depth bar: **fluent, can build a prototype, understand the data, tell the story — not an engineer.** Every project ends in a **recommendation**, because that's where you win.

Related: Skills · Networking · Reading · Consulting · Edge

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1. The 4-Step Sourcing Method

This is a reusable skill, not a one-time exercise. Find a *real* problem a *real* company has, then solve a slice of it with public data. Four ways in:

Step	What you're hunting	Where to look
1. Public pain points	A problem a company has *said out loud*	**Earnings-call transcripts** (they name their own bottlenecks), **Glassdoor** (employees describe broken processes), **App Store / Play reviews**, **Reddit** (r/uberdrivers, r/starbucksbaristas), news headlines
2. Public data	Numbers to actually analyze	**Kaggle** (search the company/industry), **10-K / annual reports** (inventory turns, margins, risk factors), **CFPB complaints DB** (consumer-finance risk patterns), **Yelp** & App reviews (voice-of-customer), gov/health open data (data.gov, CDC, HHS)
3. The JD mirror	What your target roles need *solved*	Pull 5 real Program/Ops JDs → list the verbs ("reduce cost," "improve throughput," "manage risk") → build the project that demonstrates that verb
4. Your own scar tissue	Problems you already lived at Uber	Appeals queue, fraud triage, SOP gaps, escalation design — recreate with public or synthetic data. **This is your unfair advantage** — you already know the real problem

Rule of thumb: the strongest projects stack two of these — a *named* pain point (Step 1) + *real* data (Step 2). "Starbucks said in their earnings call that mobile-order throughput is a problem" + a public QSR wait-time dataset = a project nobody can wave away.

---

2. The Case-Study Format (use the SAME one every time)

Consistency is a signal. Six beats, always in this order:

1. **Problem** — 1–2 sentences, real and public. *Cite where you found it* (the earnings call, the review, the news).

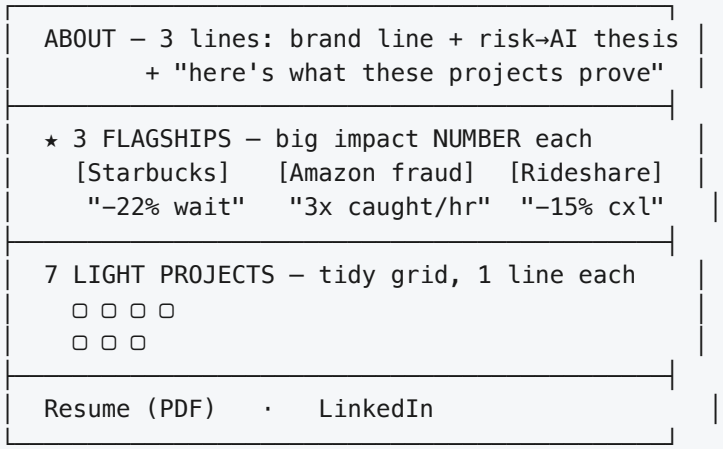
2. **Approach** — how you framed it and what you'd measure. (Your framing = your edge — spend words here.)
3. **Key finding** — one sentence, **with a number.** ("38% of returns flagged came from 6% of accounts.")
4. **What I built** — the SQL / Python / dashboard. Screenshot + link. Keep it short; the build serves the finding.
5. **Recommendation** — **your differentiator.** The specific action you'd take and the projected impact. This is the part hiring managers remember.
6. **What I'd do next** — one honest line on the limitation and the next iteration. Shows maturity, not gaps.

> Print this six-line skeleton and fill it in *before* you write a single query. If you can't state the Problem and the Recommendation-shape up front, you're not ready to build yet.

---

3. Portfolio Layout — One Clean Notion Page

One page. Scannable in 30 seconds. A hiring manager should see the numbers before they scroll.



- **About** — your brand line, the risk→AI thesis, one line on what the work proves.
- **3 flagships up top**, each with a **big number** (the Key finding). These are your interview centerpieces.
- **7 light projects in a grid** — one line + one link each. Breadth and "I ship."
- **Resume + LinkedIn** at the bottom, always linked. Also add this page to LinkedIn **Featured** (Polish, Week 17).

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4. Your 10 Projects

8 locked + 2 open. Flagships marked ★. Two projects (marked 🎯 **risk→AI**) carry your differentiator thesis — they end in a *governance* recommendation, showing you can bring risk discipline into how a team automates a decision with a model.

#	Project	Type	Skills	Weeks	Thesis
17	Lean Six Sigma DMAIC case	Light	Excel + process	**2–3**	
4	Costco inventory-turn strategy memo	Non-tech	Strategy + Excel	**3–4**	
1	★ Starbucks mobile-order throughput	**Flagship**	Excel/SQL + Power BI	**5–8**	
2	IKEA stockout & last-mile delay	Light	SQL + Power BI	**7–8**	
15	🏥 Hospital PPE stockout	Light	SQL + Power BI	**9–10**	
3	★ Amazon return-fraud triage	**Flagship**	SQL + Python	**10–12**	🎯
13	Fraud-pattern detection	Light	SQL + Python	**12–13**	🎯
5	★ Rideshare cancellation (capstone)	**Flagship**	SQL + Python + BI	**13–15**	
A	OPEN slot — your idea	Light	your call	**15**	
B	OPEN slot — your idea	Light	your call	**16**	

Full week-by-week: MASTER-SCHEDULE. Skill build order: Skills.

Project Cards

Each card: **Problem → Data → Skills → Weeks → What the Recommendation must demonstrate.**

#17 · Lean Six Sigma DMAIC case · Light · Weeks 2–3

- **Problem:** Take one documented, real, public process that has waste or defects (e.g., a clinic check-in, a drive-thru line, a returns-handling process) and run a full **Define-Measure-Analyze-Improve-Control** cycle on it.
- **Data:** A publicly documented process (company blog, ASQ / Six Sigma case libraries) + a realistic synthetic cycle-time/defect dataset you build, or a Kaggle call-center / manufacturing-defect dataset.
- **Skills:** Excel (control charts, Pareto), light SQL, DMAIC method.
- **Recommendation must demonstrate:** you can run a **rigorous improvement method end-to-end** and quantify the win — "this change cuts cycle time X%." Cashes in your **Lean Six Sigma Yellow Belt** as your very first published proof (project 1 of 10).

#4 · Costco inventory-turn strategy memo · Non-tech · Weeks 3–4 (deload-friendly)

- **Problem:** Why does Costco's low-SKU, membership model beat competitors on inventory turnover? Strategic teardown vs. Walmart / Target / BJ's.
- **Data: 10-Ks and annual reports** (compute inventory turns and days-inventory yourself from the filings), investor decks, earnings calls.
- **Skills:** Strategy + light Excel (ratios from filings). Almost no code — perfect for the August exam-crunch deload.
- **Recommendation must demonstrate:** business & financial literacy plus **strategic framing** — a crisp recommendation *for a competitor*. This is your core edge (insight, not queries) on full display, and it warms you up for the *Financial Intelligence* book later.

#1 · ★ Starbucks mobile-order throughput · FLAGSHIP · Weeks 5–8

- **Problem:** Mobile-order surges create peak-hour bottlenecks and in-store congestion — a problem **Starbucks has named in its own earnings calls**. Model the peak-hour bottleneck and staffing, then recommend a fix.
- **Data:** Starbucks **earnings-call transcripts** (the pain point in their own words) + a public QSR/restaurant wait-time or foot-traffic dataset (Kaggle) + a synthetic peak-hour order-arrival curve you model.
- **Skills:** Excel/SQL for the analysis, **Power BI** for a peak-hour throughput dashboard.
- **Recommendation must demonstrate:** a concrete **operational lever** (e.g., a dedicated mobile-order handoff station, staggered barista scheduling at peak) with a **projected throughput gain / wait-time cut**. Your first flagship on a dream company — the interview centerpiece that proves you frame a real problem and land a quantified fix (project 3 of 10).

#2 · IKEA stockout & last-mile delay · Light · Weeks 7–8

- **Problem:** Stockouts and last-mile delivery delays erode sales and customer experience — well-documented for IKEA and loud in **App Store / Trustpilot reviews**.
- **Data:** Public retail inventory/demand datasets (Kaggle), IKEA **App Store & Trustpilot reviews**, news; synthetic inventory data where needed.
- **Skills:** SQL + Power BI (deliberately reuses your Starbucks dashboard skills — faster second lap).
- **Recommendation must demonstrate:** *where* inventory breaks and a specific fix — a reorder-point / safety-stock adjustment or a last-mile lever. Shows supply-chain diagnosis on a second dream company.

#15 · 🏥 Hospital PPE stockout · Light · Weeks 9–10

- **Problem:** Hospitals ran out of PPE (masks, gowns) during demand surges. Apply a supply-chain lens to health data and prevent the next stockout.
- **Data:** Public hospital-supply / PPE datasets (data.gov, HHS, CDC), the **CDC PPE Burn-Rate** methodology (public), CMS data; synthetic burn-rate model.
- **Skills:** SQL + Power BI.
- **Recommendation must demonstrate:** a **par-level / buffer-stock or demand-forecast** recommendation that prevents stockout. Doubles as your **healthcare (B.Sc) tie-in** — a differentiated angle most PM candidates can't offer (project 5 of 10, halfway ✅).

#3 · ★ Amazon return-fraud triage · FLAGSHIP · Weeks 10–12 · 🎯 risk→AI

- **Problem:** E-commerce return fraud (wardrobing, empty-box, receipt fraud) costs retailers billions. Amazon must decide *which* returns to investigate. **Recreate your Uber fraud-triage prioritization** on public returns/e-commerce data.
- **Data:** Kaggle e-commerce transactions / returns datasets, public fraud datasets (IEEE-CIS Fraud Detection, credit-card fraud), NRF return-fraud statistics (public), synthetic returns.
- **Skills:** SQL + Python (pandas + a light risk-scoring model).
- **Recommendation must demonstrate — TWO layers:**
  1. **Ops:** a triage rule that maximizes **caught-fraud per investigator-hour.**
  2. 🎯 **Governance (the thesis):** guardrails for *safely automating* this with a model — false-positive/customer-friction thresholds, bias checks, human-in-the-loop, an audit trail. **This is where "I**

bring risk & governance discipline into how teams adopt AI safely" is shown, not claimed. Your scar-tissue flagship (project 6 of 10).

#13 · Fraud-pattern detection · Light · Weeks 12–13 · 🎯 risk→AI

- **Problem:** Detect fraud patterns in transaction data with rules + a light model. A fast spin-off of the Amazon flagship that leans on your fraud background.
- **Data:** Kaggle credit-card fraud dataset, IEEE-CIS, synthetic transactions.
- **Skills:** SQL + Python.
- **Recommendation must demonstrate:** a **rules-plus-model** detection approach **and where to draw the automation line** — precision/recall tradeoff, what to auto-block vs. flag-for-review, model monitoring. **Second project carrying the risk→AI thesis** (project 7 of 10).

#5 · ★ Rideshare cancellation · FLAGSHIP / capstone · Weeks 13–15

- **Problem:** Rider and driver cancellations hurt marketplace liquidity and CX. Why do they cancel, and which ops levers reduce it? **Your own Uber scar tissue** — the most authentic story you have.
- **Data:** Kaggle rideshare/trip datasets (Uber/Lyft/Ola cancellation data), App Store reviews and **Reddit** (r/uberdrivers) for the qualitative "why," synthetic where needed.
- **Skills:** SQL → Python → Power BI, **connected into one end-to-end pipeline** (this is the capstone — it shows the full stack works together).
- **Recommendation must demonstrate:** ops levers to reduce cancellation rate (ETA accuracy, matching radius, surge communication) with a **projected reduction %.** The capstone that proves the whole toolkit + your strategic recommendation in one artifact (project 8 of 10).

OPEN Slots A & B (your own ideas) · Weeks 15–16

Two slots are deliberately yours — pick problems *you* care about (reviews/voice-of-customer, subscription churn, a menstrual-health program design, the meta "analyze this job-search repo" idea — see spec §6a for the full menu). Before you commit a slot, run it through this checklist:

- □ **Real, nameable problem.** Can I point to an earnings call, a review thread, or a news story that says this is broken?
- □ **Public data exists.** Kaggle / 10-K / CFPB / reviews / gov data — or a defensible synthetic set. (Don't pick a problem you can't get numbers for.)
- □ **One number.** Will this produce a single Key-finding number I can put on the portfolio card?
- □ **Ends in a recommendation.** Is there a clear action + projected impact — the part that's *my* edge?
- □ **Right size.** Buildable in ~1 week at ship-fast depth (these are Light, not flagships).
- □ **Adds something new.** A skill, an industry, or the risk→AI thesis I haven't already shown.

If a slot idea checks all six, it's a good project. If it misses "one number" or "ends in a recommendation," reshape it before you start.

Cadence reminder: publish each project the week it finishes, in the six-beat format, to the Notion layout. By Week 16 all 10 are live and the portfolio is ready for Polish. Networking runs the whole time (Networking) so December isn't a cold start.

Networking Engine

← Index

> **Why this page exists:** networking is the single highest-ROI activity in your whole plan. Most jobs are filled through a warm intro, not a portal. Your portfolio proves you *can* do the work — but a person deciding to vouch for you is what gets you in the room. This page is built to be **grabbed and used**: open it, copy a message, fill the `[brackets]`, hit send.

Your one-line intro (use everywhere): "*Process & operations leader who makes things run better and cheaper — I bring risk, compliance & governance discipline into operations.*"

Related pages: Skills · Projects · Reading · Consulting · Edge

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1. The weekly cadence (non-negotiable blocks)

Slot	When	What
Chat #1	Thu (during your 3–4 hr free block)	1 coffee chat / alumni call
Chat #2	Fri	2nd alumni chat *or* a warm-lead call
Event	Fri	1 networking event (Foster mixer, industry meetup, webinar, panel)
1 DM	Mon (before class)	Send 1 new outreach message to keep the pipeline full
Review	Sun (15 min)	Update the tracker below; queue next week's asks

The math: 2 chats/week × ~20 build weeks = **40+ real conversations before you ever apply.** That is why December is *not* a cold start — by then people already know you and are watching for openings.

The rule that makes it work: applications stay light until December (your portfolio isn't ready yet — see Projects) **but networking runs hot the entire time.** Relationships take weeks to warm; skills you can cram. So front-load the slow thing.

Mindset: you're not asking for a job. You're asking to *learn* — about a team, a company, a career path. Curiosity is warm and gets replies. Desperation is cold and gets ignored. Every template below is built on that.

---

2. Copy-paste message templates

> Fill every `[bracket]`. Keep them short — long messages read as work. Send LinkedIn connection notes and short DMs; save the longer versions for email or a message *after* they connect.

Template 1 — Cold alumni outreach (UW Foster)

```
Hi [Name], I'm Bhumika — an incoming UW Foster MSCM student (starting June 2026).
I came from a risk & compliance / operations background at Uber, and I'm exploring
[program management / operations] roles at companies like [Company].

I saw you went through Foster and are now at [Company] — I'd love to hear how that
transition went for you. Would you be open to a quick 15-min chat in the next couple
of weeks? Totally understand if you're heads-down.

Thanks either way — go Huskies!
Bhumika
```

Template 2 — Warm follow-up / no-reply nudge

Send ~5–7 days after no reply. One nudge only — then let it rest.

```
Hi [Name], floating this back up in case it slipped past — totally get how busy things
get. Still would love 15 minutes to hear about your path to [Company / role] whenever
it's convenient. Happy to work entirely around your calendar. Thanks so much!
```

Template 3 — Coffee-chat request (once they've replied / you have a warm lead)

```
Thank you, [Name]! Here are a few windows that work on my end — happy to flex to
whatever's easiest for you:
  • [Day, time]
  • [Day, time]
  • [Day, time]

15–20 minutes is plenty. I can call, Zoom, or grab coffee if you're in Seattle.
Really looking forward to it.
```

Template 4 — Post-chat thank-you

Send within 24 hours. Reference one specific thing — it proves you listened.

```
Hi [Name], thank you so much for the time today — I really valued your perspective on
[specific thing they said, e.g. "how your team scopes a program before kickoff"].

The point about [second specific takeaway] especially stuck with me — I'm going to
[small concrete action you'll take because of it].

I'll keep you posted as I move through my search. Thanks again for being so generous
with your time!
Bhumika
```

Template 5 — Referral ask

Only after a real conversation — never on first contact. This is the Doc3 phrasing.

```
Hi [Name], I really valued our conversation about [Company / team] — it confirmed this
is exactly the kind of work I want to move toward.

I noticed [Company] has an opening for [Role title] ([link]). Given what we talked
about, I think it's a strong fit for my ops + risk background. Would you be comfortable
referring me, or pointing me to the right person on the team? Totally understand if
it's not the right time — no pressure at all.

Either way, thank you — our chat genuinely helped me think about this more clearly.
```

Template 6 — Networking-event follow-up

Send within 48 hours of the event, while they still remember your face.

```
Hi [Name], great to meet you at [event] — I really enjoyed our conversation about
[topic you discussed]. I'd love to stay connected as I dig into [program management /
operations] roles here in Seattle. Sending a connection request now — hope our paths
cross again soon!
```

Template 7 — "Keep me on your radar" note

For strong contacts you can't help right now — keeps the door open for December.

```
Hi [Name], hope you're doing well! Quick update: I've been building out a portfolio of
operations / process-improvement case studies ([portfolio link]) and I'll be actively
interviewing starting this December.

No ask today — just wanted to stay on your radar. If you ever hear of a
[program / project management] opening on your team or nearby, I'd love for you to think
of me. Thanks, [Name] — always great staying in touch!
```

---

3. Target-company tracker

> Pre-seeded with your dream employers + Seattle tier-1. Fill contacts as you find them (see §5), update **Status** each Sunday, and always leave yourself a **Next action** so you never open this cold.
>
> **Status key:** ⬜ Not started · 🟡 Contacted · 🔵 Chatted · 🟢 Referral in motion

Company	Role type	Contact 1	Contact 2	Status	Next action
Starbucks	Program/Ops Mgr				Find 1 Foster alum in HQ ops
IKEA	Supply Chain / Ops				Search alumni in US supply chain
Amazon	TPM / Program Mgr				Find Foster alum in Amazon ops/PM; ask for warm intro
Uber	Ops / Risk (network)				Re-activate 2 ex-colleagues
Spotify	Program Mgr				Find Seattle/remote PM contact
Microsoft	Program Mgr / TPM				Foster alumni search
Costco	Ops / Merch Ops				Issaquah HQ alum search
Boeing	Program Mgr / SCM				Everett/Renton alum search
Nordstrom	Ops / Merch Ops				Seattle HQ alum search
REI	Supply Chain / Ops				Kent DC / HQ contact
T-Mobile	Program Mgr				Bellevue HQ alum search
Expedia	Program / Product Ops				Seattle waterfront HQ contact

Target: 2 named contacts per company by mid-November (Week 19, see Master Schedule).

---

4. Coffee-chat question bank

> Ask 4–6, not all 10. Let it breathe — the best chats go off-script. Save the referral ask for *later* (Template 5), never this call.

1. How did you get into [role/team], and what surprised you most once you were in it?
2. What does a typical week actually look like — where does your time really go?
3. What separates someone who's *good* at this role from someone who's great?
4. What skills or tools does your team lean on most day-to-day? *(listen for Excel/SQL/risk — maps to Skills)*
5. When your team hires, what makes a candidate stand out — beyond the résumé?
6. How is [Company] thinking about [AI adoption / process automation] right now? *(your risk→AI thesis — a great differentiator)*
7. Looking back, what would you tell yourself starting a program/ops career today?
8. What's a problem your team is wrestling with that a fresh set of eyes could help on?
9. Is there anyone else you'd suggest I talk to as I learn about this space?

10. What's the best way to stay in touch — and how can I be useful to *you*?

Pro moves: #4 tells you what to build. #8 can become a portfolio project. #9 doubles your network from one chat. #10 flips the script — offering value is what makes you memorable.

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5. Where to find people (and the small tactics)

UW Foster alumni — your warmest cold audience:
- **LinkedIn Alumni tool** → go to the *University of Washington (Foster School of Business)* page → **Alumni** tab → filter by *Where they work* and *What they do*. Gold for Template 1.
- **Foster Career Services / MSCM program staff** — ask for the alumni directory and any mentor-matching program. Use it.
- **Foster clubs & Slack/Discord** — join the ops/SCM and consulting clubs; current students refer you to recent grads.

LinkedIn "Open to Work":
- Turn it on **for recruiters only** (the private green-ring-off setting), *not* the public banner. Recruiters can find you; hiring managers and your network don't see a "job-seeking" flag. Keeps you looking selective, not searching.

Handshake:
- UW's official recruiting platform — employers who post there *want* students specifically. Set up your profile, follow your target companies, and watch for their on-campus events and info sessions (easy Friday event slots for §1).

Events to fill the Friday slot:
- Foster mixers & info sessions · Seattle ops/supply-chain meetups (Meetup.com) · industry webinars & panels · company info sessions on Handshake · Edge case comps & hackathons (network *and* résumé line).

Two habits that compound:
- **Give before you ask.** Share an article, congratulate a promotion, intro two people. A network you've fed says yes in December.
- **Log every contact the same day** in the §3 tracker. A relationship you don't track is a relationship you'll lose.

Reading List

← Index

You read about **one book a month**, so this is built to be *browsable*, not a marathon. Four priority books are already slotted into your Build weeks (Section A). Everything else is an à-la-carte menu — grab one when you have energy, skip guilt-free when you don't.

How to read for a job search: read for the **one idea you can use this week**, not for completion. If a book gives you one framework you can name in an interview or apply to a project, it did its job — put it down and move on.

Related pages: Skills · Projects · Networking · Consulting · Edge

Section A — ⭐ Priority 4 (read first, scheduled across Build)

One per month, each paired with the projects and skills running the same weeks. Read these in order.

Book	Author	Skill it builds	Why HER specifically	Scheduled
Bulletproof Problem Solving	Conn & McLean	Structured problem-solving — issue trees, hypotheses, "define the real problem before solving it"	This *is* your edge, turned into a repeatable, nameable method. Turns "I'm good at framing problems" into "I use the 7-step problem-solving process." Also fuels your consulting fit-test running the same weeks.	**Wks 1–4**
The Goal	Goldratt	Theory of Constraints — bottleneck thinking, throughput, operations flow	It's the exact mental model behind your **Starbucks throughput flagship** (wks 5–8, same window): find the bottleneck, fix the constraint. Written as a novel — an easy read that fits the August deload. Core to the Ops / Supply Chain goal.	**Wks 5–8**
The Pyramid Principle	Minto	Top-down executive communication — lead with the answer, structure the "why"	Communication shows up in **74%** of PM job descriptions. Your differentiator is the *recommendation* at the end of each case study — this teaches you to package it so leaders act on it. Your Polish-phase STAR answers are meant to be Pyramid-structured.	**Wks 9–12**
Financial Intelligence	Berman & Knight	Business & financial literacy — read a P&L, talk cost, ROI, and budget	Your brand line is "better *and cheaper*." Budget appears in **42%** of PM JDs. This lets you speak cost-savings and ROI credibly in interviews — the language decision-makers respect.	**Wks 13–16**

Section B — Browsable menu (add as energy allows)

No schedule. Pick by which goal you want to feed that month.

Book	Skill it builds	Which goal it serves
Making Things Happen — Berkun	The craft of actually shipping projects — schedules, decisions, herding a team	#1 Program / Project Management (be the decision-maker who owns launch → implementation)
Competing Against Luck — Christensen	Jobs-to-be-Done — why customers "hire" a product; sharper problem framing	Strategic problem-solving + product-minded PM / consulting
Good Strategy Bad Strategy — Rumelt	Telling real strategy from fluff; diagnosing the core challenge	Strategic problem-solving; the consulting fit-test
Weapons of Math Destruction — O'Neil	How algorithms cause harm at scale — risk & fairness literacy	Risk / Governance → **the risk→AI thesis** (your rare, hire-me-now angle)
Never Split the Difference — Voss	Negotiation & influence without authority	Stakeholder management (**66%** of PM JDs) + your December salary negotiation
The Toyota Way — Liker	Lean, continuous improvement, respect-for-people ops culture	Ops / Supply Chain + Process Improvement (your Lean Six Sigma tie-in)

Section C — Already in your 90-Day doc (carryover — don't re-buy)

You already own or listed these. No need to purchase again — pull from the shelf when the moment fits.

- □ **The Effective Executive** — Drucker
- □ **Thinking in Systems** — Meadows
- □ **Crucial Conversations** — Patterson et al.
- □ **The Manager's Path** — Fournier
- □ **Range** — Epstein
- □ **Inspired** — Cagan

> **Reminder:** same rule applies — read for the *one idea you can use this week*, not the whole book.

Consulting — the 6-Week Fit-Test

← Index

What this is: a short, time-boxed experiment (weeks 1–6, ~2 hrs/week) to answer one question — *is consulting worth prepping for, yes or no?* — and then get out of the way. It ends in an explicit **keep-or-drop decision in Week 6**.

Why it's boxed: Consulting is your **#2-ranked direction**, behind Program/Project Management. It is being *tested, not pursued* — so it can never quietly eat the hours that belong to PM. The test is deliberately cheap: reading you'd enjoy anyway, conversations that fold into your networking blocks, and one practice case with a classmate. If the answer is no, you reclaim the hours. If yes, you add *light* case prep in November — after the portfolio is built.

> **The honest framing:** you said the pull is **problem variety + research + strategy**. That *is* what consulting is. So this test is well-aimed — you're checking a real signal, not a fantasy. Either verdict is a win: a clean "no" is as valuable as a "yes" because it removes a distraction.

The test — four cheap inputs

#	Input	What it costs	What it tells you
1	**Read / watch**	~1 hr/wk, wks 1–5	Does the *shape* of the work interest you?
2	**Talk** (2–3 consultants)	folded into networking chats	What's the job *actually* like day-to-day?
3	**Taste** (1 practice case)	~1 hr, wk 4	Does the problem-solving feel *fun* or *forced*?
4	**Decide** (Week 6)	15 min	Keep or drop — on paper, no waffling

1. Read / watch

- **Pick ONE book** (don't read both): *Case Interview Secrets* — Victor Cosentino **OR** *Case in Point* — Marc Cosentino. See Reading. Cosentino's *Case Interview Secrets* is the gentler start.
- You don't need to *finish* it. Read Ch 1–2 first (wk 2), keep going in wk 5 only if it's holding your interest. Losing interest **is data.**
- **Watch 2 "day in the life of a consultant" videos** (wk 1). Search McKinsey / BCG / Bain analyst day-in-the-life on YouTube. Notice your gut reaction to the travel, the pace, the client work.
- **One McKinsey or BCG problem-solving explainer** (wk 1–2). Search "McKinsey 7-step problem solving" or watch a BCG case walkthrough. This pairs perfectly with *Bulletproof Problem Solving* (your Week 1–4 book) — same muscle.

2. Talk — 2–3 consultants (zero extra load)

These are **not** new meetings. Aim 2–3 of your existing weekly coffee chats at people who consult (or used to). Ask them the questions that reading can't answer:
- What does a normal Tuesday actually look like?
- What do you love about it — and what made people you know leave?

- For someone with a risk/compliance + ops background, is there a natural entry lane (e.g. ops/risk-focused consulting)?
- If you had my profile, would you do it again?

3. Taste — 1 practice case (wk 4)

- Do **one** practice case out loud with a classmate (many MSCM cohorts have consulting-curious peers — great networking too).
- Use a case straight from your chosen book. You're not being graded. You're checking one thing: **did structuring the messy problem feel energizing or draining?**

Map to the schedule (weeks 1–6)

From MASTER-SCHEDULE — this is the whole footprint. All of it lives inside the August deload weeks, so it never collides with a flagship build.

Week	Dates	Consulting action (~2 hrs)
1	Jul 13–19	Watch 2 "day in the life" videos + 1 McKinsey/BCG problem-solving explainer
2	Jul 20–26	Read *Case Interview Secrets* Ch 1–2
3	Jul 27–Aug 2	1 conversation with a consultant (via a coffee chat)
4	Aug 3–9	1 practice case with a classmate
5	Aug 10–16	Continue reading *only if still interested*; 1 more consultant chat
6	Aug 17–23	⭐ **DECISION** — run the framework below, log your verdict

---

⭐ Week-6 Decision Framework

Answer these honestly. There are no wrong answers — a clean "no" frees real hours for PM.

- ☐ **The core question:** Does the work — *problem variety, research, structuring strategy* — excite me enough that I'd *want* to spend November evenings prepping cases?
- ☐ **The videos/reading:** Did the day-in-the-life pull me in, or make me tired?
- ☐ **The people:** Did the consultants I spoke to describe a life I want?
- ☐ **The case:** Did the practice case feel like *play* or like *homework*?
- ☐ **The opportunity cost:** Every hour of Nov case prep is an hour *not* spent on PM stories, mocks, and referrals. Is consulting worth that trade?

Score it simply: mostly yeses → **KEEP**. Mixed or mostly noes → **DROP**. Don't overthink; trust the gut signal the test was built to surface.

Verdict	What happens next
✅ **KEEP**	Add *light* case prep to November (Polish phase). PM stays #1 — consulting rides alongside, it does not take over. Revisit Reading for a case-prep cadence.
❌ **DROP**	Reclaim the ~2 hrs/wk. Pour them into PM: Projects, Networking, and story-building. No guilt — you *tested* it, you didn't guess.

> Whichever way it goes, consulting stops being a background "what if" question and becomes a settled decision. That clarity is the real deliverable.

📝 Log your verdict here

Fill this in during your Week 6 (Aug 17–23) Sunday review.

```
Date decided: _____________________

Verdict:   [ ] KEEP    [ ] DROP

The one signal that decided it:
_____________________________________________________________

_____________________________________________________________

If KEEP → my light Nov case-prep plan (e.g. 1 case/week with a peer):
_____________________________________________________________

If DROP → where the reclaimed ~2 hrs/week now go:
_____________________________________________________________
```

Related pages: Reading · Networking · Projects · Skills · Edge

Edge Track — "Shine Brighter"

← Index

This whole page is opportunistic, not mandatory. The core plan — skills, projects, networking — is what gets you hired. Edge moves are bonus shine: a résumé line, a strategy rep, a credibility signal. Do them *only* when they clear the filter at the bottom of this page. If August is heavy or a flagship is slipping, skip all of this guilt-free.

Why bother at all? Each edge move plays directly to your strength — **framing the real problem, then brainstorming the solution** — and gives you a story that isn't "I took a course." It's "I competed / built / co-authored."

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1. Case Competitions

Strategy muscle · résumé line · team networking — all in one weekend.

Your #1 goal is to be the **decision-maker who owns a program**. A case comp is the closest thing to that you can do before you have the job: you get a messy prompt, frame the real problem, and defend a recommendation to judges. That is your edge on display.

Where to find them:

Source	How to look
UW Foster	Ask your program office + MSCM cohort Slack/GroupMe: "Which case comps run this year?" Foster has internal case challenges and sends teams to external ones.
Grad / MBA challenges	Search "[school] MBA case competition 2026" — many accept cross-program grad teams.
Company-sponsored	Search "supply chain case competition" / "operations case challenge" + sponsor names (e.g. large retail, logistics, CPG firms run these).
Cohort teammates	Best comps are team-based — recruit 2–3 classmates. The team *is* the networking.

- □ **Week 2 (Jul 20–26):** research + list any UW Foster / external case comps with their dates → note them in the table below.
- □ Register only if the comp weekend doesn't collide with a flagship deadline (check MASTER-SCHEDULE).

Lead time: most comps open registration 3–6 weeks before the event. Decide early; teams fill up.

Why it helps: a ranked finish (or even a clean submission) is a résumé bullet, forces the exact "problem → recommendation" story you'll tell in interviews, and puts you in a room with recruiters and strong classmates.

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2. Hackathons

Pairs perfectly with a vibe-coded project — build once, count it twice.

You don't need to be an engineer. In a "supply chain / operations / automation" hackathon your value is **framing the problem and shaping the solution** while AI does the heavy lifting on code. That's the exact bar from skills: *fluent, can build a prototype, make a storyline — not an engineer.*

Devpost method:
1. Go to **devpost.com/hackathons**.
2. Filter: **Online** + status **Upcoming**.
3. Search themes: **"supply chain" · "operations" · "automation" · "logistics" · "AI for good."**
4. Look **4–6 weeks out** so you have prep runway (idea, teammate, rough plan) before the clock starts.

- □ **Week 2:** scan Devpost, note any well-timed online hackathon in the table below.
- □ **Week 8 (Aug 31–Sep 6):** re-check dates; register if one lands in Sep–Oct.
- □ **Week 11 / Week 13:** prep + hack weekend *if* registered (these are the pre-slotted windows in MASTER-SCHEDULE).

Double-dip: the thing you build at a hackathon can become one of your light portfolio projects (great fit for **OPEN slot A/B**). Never build a hackathon project that doesn't also earn a portfolio slot.

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3. Professor Paper / Research

The highest-credibility edge move — and the one with the longest lead time, so start now.

A UW Foster professor's name attached to your work says something no course certificate can: *a domain expert trusted her to contribute.* For your risk → ops → AI-governance thesis, a research line is pure gold in interviews and on LinkedIn.

How to pick a professor:
1. Browse the **Foster faculty page** for **Operations / Supply Chain Management** and **Information Systems / risk** researchers.
2. Skim 1–2 recent paper titles or abstracts each. Pick the **2–3 whose topics overlap your brand** (supply chain, operations, risk/governance, AI adoption).
3. Favor someone who **teaches a class you're in or will take** — the relationship already has a foothold.

Lead time is long (faculty reply slowly; projects ramp over weeks), so per MASTER-SCHEDULE:
- □ **Week 2 (Jul 20–26):** *draft* the outreach email (template below).
- □ **Week 3 (Jul 27–Aug 2):** *send* it to your top 1–2 professors.

Copy-paste outreach email:

```
Subject: MSCM student interested in your [supply chain / risk / ops] research

Hi Professor [Last Name],

I'm Bhumika Choudhary, a current MSCM student at Foster. Before the program
I spent [X] years at Uber as a Global SME in Risk & Compliance, where I
worked on [fraud triage / SOP design / stakeholder-facing risk programs].

I came across your work on [specific paper / topic], and it connects
directly to what I want to build my career around: bringing risk and
governance discipline into operations — including how teams adopt AI safely.

I'd love to help with a current or upcoming project — literature review,
data cleaning, analysis, or writing support. I'm comfortable with
[Excel / SQL / basic Python] and can commit roughly [3–4] hours a week
this quarter.

Could I grab 15 minutes during your office hours to hear what you're
working on and where I might be useful?

Thank you for your time,
Bhumika Choudhary
[LinkedIn URL] · [phone/email]
```

Tip: send one email per professor, personalized to their actual paper. Never BCC a batch.

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4. Optional Certifications

Only if a specific gap or job posting demands it — otherwise your portfolio is the stronger signal.

Cert	When to say yes	Effort
Lean Six Sigma Green Belt (upgrade from Yellow)	You keep seeing "Green Belt preferred" in target JDs, or you want a credential that pairs with your DMAIC project (#17). Natural next step from what you have.	Medium — self-paced course + exam
Google Project Management (Coursera)	You want a recognizable PM credential fast and a structured refresher on PM fundamentals. Good résumé keyword; light lift.	Low–medium — ~1–2 months part-time
PMP exam	**Deferred — per your call.** You're already PMP-*trained*; sitting the exam is a strong signal but a big time sink. Revisit *after* December if a target role explicitly requires the full credential.	High — not this cycle

Reality check: your data showed PMP appears in only ~19% of PM JDs and certs rarely beat a live portfolio. Treat certs as tie-breakers, not priorities.

When to Say YES to an Edge Opportunity

Run any edge move through this filter. **If it fails even one, decline — protect the core plan.**

- □ **Timing:** it does *not* collide with a flagship deadline or exam week (MASTER-SCHEDULE).

- ☐ **Leverage:** it produces a reusable asset — a résumé line, a portfolio piece, or a real relationship — not just a busy weekend.
- ☐ **On-brand:** it strengthens the story "*strategic problem-solver who brings risk/governance discipline into ops & AI.*"
- ☐ **Energy:** you actually have the bandwidth this week (not stealing from sleep, gym, or family time 🔒).

> **Rule of thumb:** at most **one** active edge move at a time. Core plan first, always. A missed edge opportunity costs nothing; a missed flagship costs you December.

Pre-scheduled edge check-ins (from MASTER-SCHEDULE): Week 2 (research + draft prof email) · Week 3 (send prof email) · Week 8 (register a hackathon/comp if one lands Sep–Oct) · Weeks 11 & 13 (hackathon prep/weekend) · Week 16 (case comp if live).

My Edge Tracker

Fill this in as you research — one row per real opportunity with a date.

Opportunity	Type	Date / deadline	Registered?	Decision
	Case comp / Hackathon / Paper / Cert		☐	
			☐	
			☐	

Related: Skills · Projects · Networking · Reading · Consulting

Master Schedule — the spine (2026-07-13 → 2026-12-27)

This is the source-of-truth timeline. Every weekly page renders one block below. Reference pages (skills, projects, networking, reading, consulting, edge) hold the detail; this says WHEN.

Fixed weekly skeleton (every week)

- **Mon** 🎓 Class 3–9pm → *light only*: 30-min read OR 1 networking DM before class
- **Tue** ✅ free → skills + project, **cap 3–4 hrs** (overflow → Sun)
- **Wed** 🎓 Class 6–9pm → 2–3 hr skills block before class
- **Thu** ✅ free → project + **1 coffee chat**, **cap 3–4 hrs** (overflow → Sun)
- **Fri** ✅ free → skills + **networking event / 2nd chat** + 1 LinkedIn post
- **Sat** 🎓 Class 9–6 · **night OFF** 🔒
- **Sun** ✅ free → Tue/Thu overflow + assignment buffer + **weekly review (15 min)**
- 🔒 always: Sat night, family calls, gym slots (habit-building)

Phase overview

Phase	Weeks	Dates	Hard checkpoint
BUILD	1–16	Jul 13 – Nov 1	Portfolio + skills done by **Oct 31**
↳ August DELOAD	4–7	Aug 3 – Aug 30	~40% lighter (exam crunch)
POLISH	17–20	Nov 2 – Nov 29	Portfolio LIVE, stories + mocks
MARKET	21–24	Nov 30 – Dec 27	Full apply, interview loops

Skill build order (per her job-data analysis)

Excel+SQL blended (wk 1) → SQL deep (every line) → Power BI → Python deep (every line, 1st project) → vibe-coding (ship-fast).

Project slotting (8 locked + 2 open)

- **[F] Flagship** = deep, full case study, interview centerpiece
- **17 Lean Six Sigma DMAIC [L] → wks 2–3 · #4 Costco strategy memo [N] → wks 3–4 (deload-friendly)**
- **#1 Starbucks throughput [F]** → wks 5–8 · #2 IKEA stockout [L] → wks 7–8
- **#15** 🏥 **Hospital PPE stockout [L]** → wks 9–10 · **#3 Amazon return-fraud [F]** → wks 10–12

- **13 Fraud-pattern detection [L] → wks 12–13 · #5 Rideshare cancellation [F] → wks 13–15**

- **OPEN slot A** → wk 15 · **OPEN slot B** → wk 16 (her own ideas)

Book slotting (Priority 4; ~1/month)

Bulletproof Problem Solving (wks 1–4) → The Goal (wks 5–8) → Pyramid Principle (wks 9–12) → Financial Intelligence (wks 13–16) → browsable menu during Polish/Market.

PER-WEEK BLOCKS

Week 1 · Jul 13–19 · BUILD · "Set up the engine"

- **Theme:** Foundations + turn the networking engine ON.
- **Skill:** Excel — pivot tables refresher + XLOOKUP (ExcelJet). SQL — SELECT/WHERE/ORDER BY (mode.com Basics 1–3). *Blend, understand every line.*
- **Project:** none yet — set up GitHub + Notion portfolio shell.
- **Book:** Start *Bulletproof Problem Solving* Ch 1–2.
- **Consulting:** Start fit-test — watch 2 "day in the life of a consultant" videos (consulting).
- **Networking:** Update LinkedIn headline+bio to new brand line. Send alumni msg #1 & #2 (Template 1). Register for 1 event.
- **Edge:** none.
- **Life:** Set gym slots; Sat night off; 1 family call.
- **Sun review:** confirm portfolio shell + LinkedIn live.

Week 2 · Jul 20–26 · BUILD · "First project, real SQL"

- **Skill:** Excel — Power Query intro. SQL — COUNT/SUM/GROUP BY + JOINs start (mode 4). Every line.
- **Project: #17 Lean Six Sigma DMAIC** kickoff — pick a public/documented process, define D-M-A-I-C scope.
- **Book:** *Bulletproof* Ch 3–4.
- **Consulting:** Read *Case Interview Secrets* Ch 1–2.
- **Networking:** 2 chats (aim 1 = a Program Manager). 1 event. LinkedIn post #1 ("I started building…").
- **Edge:** Research UW Foster case comps + Devpost supply-chain/ops hackathons; note dates in edge. Draft professor-paper outreach email.
- **Sun review:** DMAIC scope done? Prof email drafted?

Week 3 · Jul 27–Aug 2 · BUILD · "Finish light project #1"

- **Skill:** SQL — JOINs deep + subqueries (mode 5) + StrataScratch easy ×3. Excel — dashboard basics.
- **Project: #17 DMAIC** finish + write case study (Problem→…→Recommendation). Publish to GitHub+Notion.

- **Project: #4 Costco strategy memo** kickoff (strategy + Excel; low-tech, deload-friendly).
- **Book:** Finish *Bulletproof Problem Solving*.
- **Consulting:** 1 conversation w/ a consultant (via networking).
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. **Send professor-paper outreach email.**
- **Sun review:** DMAIC live on portfolio (project 1 of 10 ✅).

Week 4 · Aug 3–9 · BUILD · 🟡 DELOAD · "Ship the strategy memo, breathe"

- **Skill:** *Light* — SQL window functions intro only (mode) ~1 session.
- **Project: #4 Costco memo** finish + publish (project 2 of 10 ✅). Strategy-only, no heavy tech — good for exam week.
- **Book:** Start *The Goal* Ch 1–3.
- **Consulting:** 1 practice case with a classmate.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event (lighter if needed).
- **Life:** protect exam time; skills dialed down.
- **Sun review:** on pace despite crunch?

Week 5 · Aug 10–16 · BUILD · 🟡 DELOAD · "Start flagship #1"

- **Skill:** SQL — CTEs + window functions (kaggle Advanced SQL). Start **Power BI** (learn.microsoft.com intro).
- **Project: #1 Starbucks throughput [FLAGSHIP]** kickoff — find public data (mobile-order/peak-hour), define problem + 5 business questions.
- **Book:** *The Goal* Ch 4–6.
- **Consulting:** Continue reading; 1 more consultant chat.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. LinkedIn post #2 (reframe Uber as PM work).
- **Sun review:** Starbucks data loaded + questions written?

Week 6 · Aug 17–23 · BUILD · 🟡 DELOAD · "Consulting DECISION"

- **Skill:** Power BI — import data, build 2 visuals. SQL — apply to Starbucks queries.
- **Project: #1 Starbucks** — write SQL queries 1–3, first Power BI visuals.
- **Book:** *The Goal* Ch 7–9.
- **Consulting:** ⭐ **DECISION** — keep (add light case prep to Nov) or drop (reclaim hours). Record in consulting.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event.
- **Sun review:** consulting verdict logged.

Week 7 · Aug 24–30 · BUILD · 🟡 DELOAD · "Two projects in flight"

- **Skill:** Power BI — dashboard formatting, KPI cards, slicers.
- **Project: #1 Starbucks** — finish dashboard + queries 4–5. **#2 IKEA stockout [L]** kickoff (SQL + Power BI, reuses Starbucks skills).
- **Book:** *The Goal* Ch 10–12.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. LinkedIn post #3.
- **Sun review:** Starbucks dashboard near-done?

Week 8 · Aug 31–Sep 6 · BUILD · "Flagship #1 launches"

- **Skill:** Power BI — DAX basics (measures, calculated columns). Deload ends — back to full pace.
- **Project: #1 Starbucks [F]** finish + full case study + publish (project 3 of 10 ✅). **#2 IKEA** continue.
- **Book:** Finish *The Goal*.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. LinkedIn post #4 (Starbucks flagship launch + GitHub link).
- **Edge:** check hackathon/case-comp dates; register if one lands in Sep–Oct.
- **Sun review:** flagship #1 LIVE.

Week 9 · Sep 7–13 · BUILD · "IKEA out, healthcare in, Python begins"

- **Skill: Python** Day 1–10 (Angela Yu / Kaggle Python) — variables, loops, functions. *Every line.*
- **Project: #2 IKEA** finish + publish (project 4 of 10 ✅). **#15** 🏥 **Hospital PPE stockout [L]** kickoff.
- **Book:** Start *The Pyramid Principle* Ch 1–3.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event.
- **Sun review:** IKEA live; Python Days 1–10 done?

Week 10 · Sep 14–20 · BUILD · "Python + flagship #2 start"

- **Skill: Python** Day 11–17 (file I/O, pandas) + Kaggle Pandas 1–3. Every line.
- **Project: #15** 🏥 **PPE** finish + publish (project 5 of 10 ✅). **#3 Amazon return-fraud [FLAGSHIP]** kickoff — recreate fraud-triage on public e-commerce/returns data.
- **Book:** *Pyramid Principle* Ch 4–6.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. LinkedIn post #5.
- **Sun review:** PPE live (5/10 ✅, halfway); Amazon scoped?

Week 11 · Sep 21–27 · BUILD · "Build flagship #2"

- **Skill:** Python — pandas deep (groupby, filtering, clean). Every line (interview insurance).
- **Project: #3 Amazon fraud [F]** — SQL + Python triage logic; first findings.
- **Book:** *Pyramid Principle* Ch 7+.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event.
- **Edge:** hackathon prep if registered.
- **Sun review:** Amazon triage logic working?

Week 12 · Sep 28–Oct 4 · BUILD · "Flagship #2 launches, fraud spin-off"

- **Skill:** Python — finish pandas; light intro to a model (optional).
- **Project: #3 Amazon fraud [F]** finish + case study + publish (project 6 of 10 ✅). **#13 Fraud-pattern detection [L]** kickoff (reuses Amazon work).
- **Book:** Finish *Pyramid Principle*.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. LinkedIn post #6 (flagship #2 launch).
- **Sun review:** flagship #2 LIVE.

Week 13 · Oct 5–11 · BUILD · "Vibe-coding + capstone start"

- **Skill: Vibe-coding** — build a small app with AI (ship-fast, understand the shape). Reuse for a light project.

- **Project: #13 Fraud-pattern** finish + publish (project 7 of 10 ✅). **#5 Rideshare cancellation [FLAGSHIP/capstone]** kickoff — SQL+Python+BI.
- **Book:** Start *Financial Intelligence* Ch 1–3.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event.
- **Edge:** hackathon weekend if scheduled.
- **Sun review:** capstone scoped?

Week 14 · Oct 12–18 · BUILD · "Build the capstone"

- **Skill:** Vibe-coding — polish the app; connect pieces.
- **Project: #5 Rideshare [F]** — connect SQL → Python → Power BI into one flow. **OPEN slot A** kickoff (her idea).
- **Book:** *Financial Intelligence* Ch 4–6.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. LinkedIn post #7.
- **Sun review:** capstone pipeline working end-to-end?

Week 15 · Oct 19–25 · BUILD · "Capstone launches"

- **Skill:** Consolidation — no new skill; apply to projects.
- **Project: #5 Rideshare [F]** finish + full case study + publish (project 8 of 10 ✅). **OPEN slot A** finish (9/10 ✅).
- **Book:** *Financial Intelligence* Ch 7+.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event.
- **Sun review:** capstone LIVE.

Week 16 · Oct 26–Nov 1 · BUILD · ⭐ "BUILD ENDS — portfolio complete"

- **Skill:** Finish *Financial Intelligence*.
- **Project: OPEN slot B** finish (project 10 of 10 ✅). Polish all 10 case studies to the consistent format.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. LinkedIn post #8 (portfolio complete).
- **Edge:** case comp if live.
- **Sun review:** ⭐ **END-OF-BUILD CHECK** — 10 projects live? Excel/SQL/BI/Python credible? 25+ chats done? Portfolio ready for Polish?

Week 17 · Nov 2–8 · POLISH · "Portfolio goes fully LIVE"

- **Focus:** Notion portfolio final layout; toggle public; add to LinkedIn Featured + resume header.
- **Stories:** Write 5 STAR answers (Pyramid-structured) from Uber + projects.
- **Interview:** Mock interview #1 (behavioral + portfolio walkthrough).
- **Consulting:** case prep IF kept.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. Ask 2 contacts for referrals.
- **Book:** browsable menu — start one (e.g. *Making Things Happen*).
- **Sun review:** portfolio public + linked everywhere?

Week 18 · Nov 9–15 · POLISH · "Sharpen the story"

- **Focus:** Resume final rewrite (every bullet PM/ops language). Portfolio walkthrough script.

- **Stories:** 5 more STAR answers. Record yourself; watch back once.
- **Interview:** Mock #2.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. 2 referral asks.
- **Sun review:** resume final?

Week 19 · Nov 16–22 · POLISH · "Company-target the pipeline"

- **Focus:** Target-company tracker (dream list + 2 contacts each). Tailor 3 master résumé variants (PM / Ops / Risk).
- **Interview:** Mock #3 (company-specific).
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. Convert referral asks.
- **Sun review:** tracker built, variants ready?

Week 20 · Nov 23–29 · POLISH · "Ready to launch"

- **Focus:** Dry-run 5 applications (don't submit yet). Final portfolio + resume QA.
- **Interview:** Mock #4.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event.
- **Life:** rest before December sprint.
- **Sun review:** ⭐ **POLISH CHECK** — portfolio live, stories sharp, 4 mocks done, tracker ready, referrals in motion.

Week 21 · Nov 30–Dec 6 · MARKET · "Hit the market"

- **Apply:** 5 tailored applications (dream + target companies). Use find-jobs pipeline for fresh listings.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. Ask contacts to flag openings.
- **Interview:** prep for any early responses.
- **Sun review:** 5 quality apps in.

Week 22 · Dec 7–13 · MARKET · "Ramp applications"

- **Apply:** 5 more (total 10). Follow up on week-21 apps.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. Direct referral asks at target companies.
- **Interview:** loops beginning — prep per company.
- **Sun review:** any movement?

Week 23 · Dec 14–20 · MARKET · "Interview mode"

- **Apply:** 5 more (total 15+).
- **Interview:** active loops — company-specific prep, portfolio walkthroughs.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. Check in with contacts.
- **Sun review:** interview loops live?

Week 24 · Dec 21–27 · MARKET · "Reflect + sustain"

- **Apply:** 5 more (total 20+).
- **Interview:** continue loops.
- **Reflect:** what's working; adjust for January.

- **Ongoing cadence after this:** 2 apps/day + 2 chats/week + 1 book/month until landed.
- **Sun review:** ⭐ **YEAR-END CHECK** — 20+ apps, interview loops in motion, portfolio doing the talking.